

101 Habakkuk

The prophet who argued with God and learned to rejoice when everything failed.

Habakkuk is different from most prophets. Instead of carrying God's word to the people, he brings the people's questions to God. He lived in Judah shortly before the Babylonian invasions, and he was troubled by the violence and injustice he saw around him. Why did God not act? God's answer shocked him: he was raising up the Chaldeans, the Babylonians, to judge Judah. That raised a harder question. How could a holy God use a nation more wicked than Judah? Habakkuk climbed his watchtower to wait. God told him that "the just shall live by his faith." His book ends with a song of trust that has comforted believers in hard times ever since.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Chavaquq</i> , possibly from a word meaning "embrace"
Family	Not recorded
Title	"Habakkuk the prophet" (Habakkuk 1:1; 3:1)
When	Probably c. 605 BC, as Babylon rose to power (dates of c. 610–600 BC are also proposed)
Key places	Judah; his watchtower; the temple (Habakkuk 2:1, 20)
Main passages	Habakkuk 1–3
New Testament	Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:37–38; Acts 13:40–41

"Yet I will rejoice in the LORD, I will joy in the God of my salvation."

Habakkuk 3:18, KJV

The life of Habakkuk

Dates are approximate (BC). Habakkuk gives no date or king. Most scholars place him around the time Babylon defeated Egypt at Carchemish in 605 BC (Jeremiah 46:2). His book is a conversation, so the entries follow its order.

- c. 605 BC

Before the invasion

● "How long?"

Habakkuk cries out that he sees violence, strife and injustice, and God does not seem to hear or save.
Habakkuk 1:1-4
- c. 605 BC

God's first answer

● The Chaldeans are coming

God says he is raising up the Chaldeans, "that bitter and hasty nation," and Judah will not believe it even when told. *Habakkuk 1:5-11*
- c. 605 BC

His second complaint

● Why use the wicked?

He asks how a God of purer eyes than to behold evil can let a more wicked nation swallow a more righteous one.
Habakkuk 1:12-17
- On the watchtower

● Waiting for God

He decides to stand on his watch and see what God will say. God tells him to write the vision plainly and wait for it, for it will surely come. *Habakkuk 2:1-4*
- After the vision

● A prayer and a song

He prays, "in wrath remember mercy," recalls God's mighty deeds, and resolves to rejoice in God even if every crop fails. *Habakkuk 3:1-19*

Group notes

Key activities

Habakkuk 2:4 has been read in several ways. The Hebrew word for "faith" can also mean "faithfulness." Paul quotes the verse to show that the righteous live by trusting God.

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- 1 Asked God hard questions.** "O LORD, how long shall I cry, and thou wilt not hear!" *Habakkuk 1:2-4*

 - 2 Received a shocking answer.** God said he would do a work that Judah would not believe: send the Babylonians. *Habakkuk 1:5-6*

 - 3 Pressed his case.** He appealed to God's holiness: "Thou art of purer eyes than to behold evil." *Habakkuk 1:12-13*

 - 4 Waited on the watchtower.** "I will stand upon my watch, and set me upon the tower, and will watch to see what he will say unto me." *Habakkuk 2:1*

 - 5 Wrote the vision plainly.** God told him to write it on tablets so that anyone could read it and run. *Habakkuk 2:2-3*

 - 6 Heard the heart of the answer.** The proud will fall, but "the just shall live by his faith." *Habakkuk 2:4*

 - 7 Announced five woes.** He pronounced woe on greed, violence, cruelty and idolatry. "The earth shall be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD." *Habakkuk 2:6-20*

 - 8 Sang his trust.** Though the fig tree fail and the fields yield no food, he would rejoice in the God of his salvation. *Habakkuk 3:17-19*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Habakkuk.

Old Testament

Habakkuk 1–3	The book of his complaints, God's answers and his prayer.
Echoes	Jeremiah also asked why the wicked prosper (Jeremiah 12:1). Job and many psalmists bring honest complaints to God (Job 23:3–4; Psalm 13:1). "Be still, and know that I am God" (Psalm 46:10).

New Testament

Romans 1:17	and Galatians 3:11 . Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4, "The just shall live by faith," at the heart of his teaching on the gospel.
Hebrews 10:37–38	Hebrews quotes Habakkuk 2:3–4 to encourage believers to wait patiently for Christ.
Acts 13:40–41	Paul warns his hearers with Habakkuk 1:5: "Behold, ye despisers, and wonder, and perish."
Echoes	Paul and Silas sing in prison at midnight (Acts 16:25). Paul learned to be content in every circumstance (Philippians 4:11–13).

For discussion

- Observe:* What two questions did Habakkuk ask God (Habakkuk 1:2–4, 12–13)?
- Understand:* Why do you think God answered Habakkuk with a call to faith instead of a full explanation?
- Apply:* What question would you most like to bring to God right now? What would it look like to wait on the watchtower with it?
- Apply:* Finish Habakkuk's sentence for your own life: "Although ... yet I will rejoice in the LORD." What would you write?